



Open to all: Luki Uriarte, director of grassroots football with Real Sociedad, says attracting talent from around the world is key to building a strong side.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT / LA LIGA

Real and Athletic have contrasting methods when it comes to their football teams. Real seems to prioritise the game over everything else, while Athletic tries to establish a unique identity. Real allows its academy players to leave and then signs non-Basque players to take their place. Meanwhile, Athletic makes every effort to promote its academy players to the first team. Two recent examples of this approach are Unai Simon and Nico Williams, who both came from Lezama and are now part of the Spanish national team. While Williams has already signed a long-term contract with Athletic, Simon reportedly has a verbal agreement in place.

In the Indian context, football teams in Goa experimented with the

strategy of prioritising local talent. Esteemed clubs like Churchill Brothers and Dempo SC exclusively fielded local players in the Goa Premier League, except for foreign signings. However, this approach, as noted by Pradhyum Reddy, the Chief Executive Officer of Dempo Sporting Club, was deemed unsustainable.

"In Goa now, you look at clubs like Vasco; they are getting players from other states. There were a lot of Goa players back in the day, no doubt. For example, Dempo went with a Goan squad last season in the second division, and we came up short. This year, we decided to include players from outside, and we won our group," says Reddy.

"If you are trying to be a top team, then maybe you need to get good players from everywhere through scouting. It is unlikely that one region in India is going to produce everything you need in every position," he adds.

Limiting a football club's recruitment to only local players would hinder its potential. Steve

Charles, a scout working in Mizoram for the Reliance Foundation Young Champs, explains that genetics vary across India and that by diversifying the squad with players from different regions, the club can benefit from a more well-rounded team with a variety of skill sets.

"Players up north are bigger in frame. Down south, [the physique] is above average; in the North-East, they're not among the tallest people. In the South, you see a lot of creative players; you see a number 10, a number eight. They are runners. They are box-to-box. They have a high level of endurance. So that could be to their advantage. In the North-East, you see a lot of very pacey wingers, whose centre of gravity is low.

"Considering that, we are moving in a direction to really understand the positional requirements of the ISL clubs and national team," Charles had said in a previous interview with Sportstar.

Back in Bilbao, Athletic has carved a path around this lack of diversity by